HEREFORDSHIRE

COUNTY BRIDEWELL

HEREFORD. On the castle green, is quite out of repair. Indeed it is not only ruinous, but dangerous: a cross wall is parted a great way from the wall against which it abutted. In the day-room there was a large quantity of water from the roof. No fire-place: offensive sewers: no court: no water: no stated allowance: no employment. Keeper's salary, £10. He told me that a little before I came, a prisoner died after three weeks' confinement. Six prisoners, whom I saw there at my first visit, complained of being almost famished. They were sent hither from the assize a few days before to hard labour (as the sentence usually runs) for six months. The justices had ordered the keeper to supply each of them daily with a twopenny loaf: but he had neglected them. They broke out soon after.

GLOUCESTERSHIRE

COUNTY GAOL, GLOUCESTER CASTLE

The castle is also one of the county bridewells: yet only one court for all prisoners; and one day-room (eleven feet nine inches by ten feet seven), for men and women felons. The free ward for debtors is nineteen feet by eleven, which having no window, part of the plaster wall is broken down for light and air. The night-room (the main) for men felons, though up many stone steps, is close and dark; and the floor is so ruinous, that it cannot be washed. Adjoining to the main, there are other night-rooms for fines, etc. These have also their separate day-room. The whole prison was much out of repair, and had not been whitewashed for many years. The upper rooms were the bridewell; but at my last visit they were used for an infirmary. Many prisoners died here in 1773, and I generally saw some sick in this gaol; eight died about Christmas 1778 of the small-pox; and in 1783, several died of that disorder and the gaol-fever. Only one sewer. No bath. Neither clauses against spirituous liquors, nor the Act for preserving the health of prisoners, are hung up.

There is no separation of the women, or of the bridewell

prisoners. The licentious intercourse of the sexes is shocking to decency and humanity. Many children have been born in this gaol. There is a small chapel, but all the endeavours of the chaplain to promote reformation among the prisoners must necessarily be defeated, by the inattention of the magistrates, and their neglect of framing and enforcing good regulations. Perhaps this is the reason the chaplain seldom attends.

Of the felons, etc., in September and December, 1776, thirteen were transports: most of them convicted at Lent assize 1775. About twenty were fines; who, not having the county allowance, nor any employment, were in September very pitiable objects indeed; half naked, and almost famished. But in December their appearance was much altered. Mr. Raikes[1] and other gentlemen took pity on them, and generously contributed toward the feeding and clothing them. Mr. Raikes continues his unremitting attention to the prisoners. Eleven of the twenty-four in 1779, sixteen in 1782, and fourteen in 1783, were fines without any employment or allowance. The gaoler has £10 a year as bridewell keeper.

In this gaol were some prisoners, who had been arrested by exchequer writs; in which an officer is commanded "to bring the body before the barons of the exchequer—at Westminster —to answer our sovereign lord the king concerning divers trespasses, contempts, and offences, etc." The prisoners are called contempts. In different parts of the kingdom, there are many prisoners detained by such writs.

At my visit in December 1782, I found some improvements made in the castle: the floors laid with stone; boxes or bedsteads for the felons and fines; and the whole prison whitewashed. When prisons are repaired, particular care should be taken for the admission of air. The windows should not be close glazed. I observed numbers of the townsmen drinking in the tap-room here, as in too many other gaols.

[1] This gentleman is also the founder of a benevolent and useful institution for the children of the poor in this city. Having observed great numbers of them in this manufacturing place to spend their Sundays in an idle and dissolute manner, he established several little schools for their instruction on the evenings of that day; which, by his attention and liberal encouragement, have had a happy effect in improving the morals of the younger classes; many of whom now look up to their kind benefactor with great esteem and affection. Perhaps Mr. Raikes's frequent visits to the castle suggested to him this plan, as the best means of preventing youth from coming there.[2]

[2] Mr. Raikes's Sunday Schools spread, and a statue in the Charing Cross Embankment Gardens, London, commemorates him as the founder of the movement.—[Ed.]